Proposal Part B: technical description

FOSTERING INNOVATION CULTURE TO BOOST CAREERS OF NEW GENERATION OF GEORGIAN ARTIFICIAL INTELLIGENCE RESEARCHERS (FORGE-AI)

[This document is tagged. Do not delete the tags; they are needed for processing.] #@APP-FORM-HECSA@#

Table of Contents

0. HISTORY OF CHANGES 2
1. EXCELLENCE 4
1.1. OBJECTIVES 5
1.2. COORDINATION AND/OR SUPPORT MEASURES AND METHODOLOGY 9
1.2.1 CAREER BOOSTING SKILLS DEVELOPMENT 10
1.2.2 CROSS-SECTOR SECONDMENT PROGRAMME 12
1.2.3 INNOVATION POLICIES AND PRACTICES ADJUSTMENT 14
1.2.4 OPEN SCIENCE AND DATA MANAGEMENT 14
2. IMPACT 17
2.1 PROJECT'S PATHWAYS TOWARDS IMPACT 17
2.1.1 STRATEGIC IMPACT 17
2.1.2 CONTRIBUTION TO EXPECTED OUTCOMES 17
2.1.3 KEY PERFORMANCE INDICATORS 18
2.2 MEASURES TO MAXIMIZE IMPACT - DISSEMINATION, EXPLOITATION AND COMMUNICATION 19
2.3 SUMMARY 23
3. QUALITY AND EFFICIENCY OF THE IMPLEMENTATION 25
3.1 WORK PLAN AND RESOURCES 25
3.2 CAPACITY OF PARTICIPANTS AND CONSORTIUM AS A WHOLE 25
TABLES FOR SECTION 3.1 27
TABLE 3.1G: 'SUBCONTRACTING COSTS' ITEMS 27
TABLE 3.1H: 'PURCHASE COSTS' ITEMS (TRAVEL AND SUBSISTENCE, EQUIPMENT AND OTHER GOODS, WORKS AND SERVICES) 27
OTHER COSTS CATEGORIES' ITEMS (E.G. INTERNALLY INVOICED GOODS AND SERVICES) 31
IN-KIND CONTRIBUTIONS' PROVIDED BY THIRD PARTIES 31
AFFILIATED ENTITIES 31
ASSOCIATED PARTNERS 31
4. ETHICS SELF-ASSESSMENT 31
4.1. ETHICAL DIMENSION OF THE OBJECTIVES, METHODOLOGY AND LIKELY IMPACT 31
4.2. COMPLIANCE WITH ETHICAL PRINCIPLES AND RELEVANT LEGISLATIONS 31

0. History of changes

Table. History of changes

Page/section	Nature of change and reason
Part A	
List of Deliverables	Added: D 2.1 Career Development Plan
List of Deliverables WP 2	Former D2.1 Secondment programme detailed plan is changed as D 2.2 Secondment programme report. Initial version. Due date M18 was changed as M12. Description not changed. Former D 2.2 Secondment programme technical report is changed as D 2.3 Secondment programme report. Intermediate version. Due date M33 was changed as M30. Description changed - The deliverable provides account of secondment programme activities and all Individual Secondment reports. Former D 2.3 Secondment programme impact evaluation is changed as D 2.4 Secondment programme report. Final version. Due month 36 – not changed. Description not changed.
List of Deliverables WP 4	Former D4.2 Dissemination and Communication Plan is splitted into: D 4.2 Plan for dissemination and exploitation including communication activities, version 1 (description not changed), and D 4.4 Plan for dissemination and exploitation including communication activities, version 2. Description added - Updated plan for dissemination and exploitation including communication activities in the middle of the project. D 4.6 Final dissemination report is renamed as D 4.6 Final dissemination, exploitation and communication report. Description changed - The report providing information on project dissemination, exploitation and communication activities, and their impact.
List of Deliverables WP 5	Former D5.2 Data management plan is splitted into D 5.2 Data management plan, version 1 description not changed) and D 5.3 Data management plan, version 2. Due date M18. Description added - Updated DMP at the middle of the project. Includes the information about the datasets available at this point of time.
Table 3.1.f, Summary of staff effort	Three figures in the last row Total Person Months, namely the sums of columns of WP1, WP2 and Total p/m-s, are incorrect, 81, 295 and 526 respectively. They were changed by the correct figures 78, 294 and 522 respectively. Mistake is due to incorrect calculation in columns.
Risks Table	Risk #10 added
Part B	
p. 1	Table of contents added
Tables for section 3.1	Tables 3.1a (List of work packages), Table 3.1b (Work package description), Table 3.1c (List of Deliverables), Table 3.1d (List of milestones) and Table 3.1f (Summary of staff effort) removed
Table 2. FORGE-AI Operational objectives, Obj. 2, Evaluation, p. 7	"target value: 234 months" is changed by "target value: 228 months"
Sec, 1.2.2 Cross-sector secondment programme, p. 12	In The principles of the secondment programme design, 1…. The focus will be on researchers, their secondment/months compose more than 75% of the programme. The percent 75% was changed as 43% (228 pm out of total 522 pm): 1 … The focus will be on researchers, their secondment/months compose more than 43% of the programme.

Sec, 1.2.2 Cross-sector secondment programme, p. 12	"The planned secondments are in line with the rules of the call" added under the second bullet
Sec, 1.2.2 Cross-sector secondment programme, p. 13, #5	The text was extended with the following sentences: "All secondees upon their return will be invited to report whether or not the commitments of sending organizations are fulfilled. All cases of complains will be discussed by the Project Coordination Committee to identify the reasons and take corrective measures wherever possible (e.g. direct communication with the management of sending organizations). An additional role in the secondees' reintegration will play the FORGE-AI Alumni and GAIA, as both will extend professional networking opportunities for community reintegration."
Sec, 1.2.2 Cross-sector secondment programme, p. 13	1st, 2nd and 4th bullets at the end of the section • Each secondee will get travel support (1200 euro per secondment). If during the secondment the need to travel (e.g. conference attendance, research visit, etc.) emerges and the anticipated costs are exceed the initial sum of 1200 euro, the sending organization will be in charge of costs covering • For each month of secondment a secondee will receive the allowance of 1,500 euro to cover accommodation and per diems (in line with national standards) • The costs associated with the secondment programme implementation (travel costs, costs of stay and salaries of secondees allocated to the Georgian sending organizations) are estimated as 923,800 euro, which represent more than 1/3 of the total project costs. were changed as • Each secondee will get travel support (estimated costs in range 750 - 790 euro per secondment). If during the secondment the need to travel (e.g. conference attendance, research visit, etc.) emerges and the anticipated costs exceed the initial sum, the sending organization will be in charge of costs covering. • For each month of secondment a secondee will receive the allowance (estimated costs in range 1400 - 1700 euro per secondment) to cover accommodation and per diems (in line with national standards). • The costs associated with the secondment programme implementation (travel costs, costs of stay and salaries of secondees allocated to the Georgian sending organizations) are estimated as 888,800 euro, which represent more than 32% of the total project costs.
Table 3 – Secondments between beneficiaries, p.15	For the last, 25th secondment, the duration months 12 is changed by 6. This is in line with the total 69 pm-s of TSU in WP2, consisting of 66 pm-s for secondments implementation, plus 3 for secondment programme launch and secondees selection. The reason of a mistake made in proposal is that we added the Armenian partner on the last day to the submission deadline.
Sec, 2.1.1 Strategic impact, p. 16	Text added: "The project will focus on young AI talents (professionals of age 25-30, up to 35 as an exception) - this priority will be observed while inviting the participants for training and will be a selection criterion for secondments. This approach allows to provide a push to the selected AI talents right at the beginning of their professional life thus enabling them to pursue a multi-optional career path".
Table in Section 2.1.3 Key performance indicators, p.17	Overall volume of the secondment programme (in secondment/months), 234 was changed by 228.
Section 2.3 Summary, key element of the impact section, expected results, p.22	Second Bullet • A cohort of 25 AI R&I talents spent in total 234 months on cross-sector secondments in Europe/region and improved cross-sector employability Was changed by • A cohort of 25 AI R&I talents spent in total 210 months on cross-sector secondments in Europe/region, plus 18 months in Armenia, and improved cross-sector employability

Section 3.1, Work plan and resources, 2nd bullet, p. 25	"…talents accounting to 234 person/months…" was changed by "…talents accounting to 228 person/months…"
Budget allocation table, p. 25	Budget allocated to non-Widening countries: 833,375.00 euro was changed by the correct amount 798,750.00 euro. Total EU requested budget: 2,785,500.00 euro was changed by the correct amount 2,750,875.00 euro. Percentages for Budget allocated to Widening countries (70%) and Budget allocated to non-Widening countries (30%) were changed by 71% and 29% respectively.
Table 3.1g, Subcontracting costs items, p. 25	Added: No subcontracting planned
p.25	Table 3.1h, Purchase costs, with explanations added.
Table 3.1h, Purchase costs, p.25	Initial Travel cost 122,200 euro for GTU, was reduced to 118,850 euro. 3350 euro was added to "Other goods and services" and will be used to organize a final conference. The reason for this change was the costs for Certificate on the financial statements (CFS) estimated as 7000 euro, which was not considered before.
p.29	Remarks added under the Table 3.1h,
p. 29	Added: No affiliated entities are foreseen in the project.
p. 29	Added: No associated partners are foreseen in the project
p. 29	Added: Ethics self-assessment

1. Excellence #@REL-EVA-RE@#

FORGE-AI in a nutshell

WHY	In order to keep pace with the unfolding AI revolution Georgia, one of the EU Candidate countries, urgently **needs a new cohort of AI R&I talents** capable of pursuing successful careers in academic and industrial environments. The current R&I system provides insufficient opportunities for attracting and retaining such talents. The existing Governmental funding instruments targeted at young researchers need adjustments to facilitate cross-sector career development and knowledge circulation.
WHAT	The project will contribute to strengthening the innovation focus of AI research in Georgia and bridging the gap between academia and industry by enabling young AI R&I talents to pursue cross-sector careers.
HOW	The project work plan is composed of the following sets of tasks: • Comprehensive **capacity building programme** focused on young researchers, research managers and innovators • Pilot **cross-sector & cross-border secondment programme** allowing a representative cohort of AI R&I talents to get exposed to European R&I practices • Adjustments in **national policy and funding instruments** targeting young R&I talents and aimed at increasing the focus on innovation by integrating the experiences acquired thanks to FORGE-AI
FOR WHOM	For young AI researchers in academia, including those pursuing postgraduate degrees. Research staff of research-intensive AI companies, including startups. Research administrators and managers in academic and non-academic organizations. Managerial staff of national R&I agencies.
BY WHOM	A **unique consortium** involving all relevant stakeholders of Georgian R&I system in the field of AI comprehensively representing the R&I community. The Georgian core is supported by leading and large European AI research and innovation organizations jointly bringing in all necessary expertise. The regional dimension is supported by an AI research company from Armenia

The FORGE-AI project aims to significantly improve the innovation potential of the Georgia's Research and Innovation (R&I) system and provide a sustainable conditions for boosting research careers of young researchers across sectors, especially in the area of Artificial Intelligence (AI), by (1) strengthening innovation-related capacities of leading young AI researchers and research managers ("Talents"); (2) introducing and demonstrating the added value of cross-sectoral mobility & knowledge circulation, and (3) modernizing the national innovation supporting funding mechanisms to incorporate career-boosting principles and activities. In order to attain this goal, the consortium comprising in Georgia:

- 2 national research and innovation funding agencies (SRNSF and GITA),
- 2 major national Universities (classic and technical ones) jointly employing more than 50% of all Georgian researchers and more than 65% of those in the field of AI (GTU and TSU),
- 3 successful AI startup companies (DAL, HelioAI, AILab),
- National AI association, a cross-sectoral community-driven network (GAIA),
- and Horizon Europe Cluster 4 National Contact Point (ICARTI)

supported by the relevant European expert organizations:

- German Research Centre for AI, one of the world's largest non-profit research organizations in this field of AI (DFKI),
- Innovation and Entrepreneurship ecosystem of Saarland University, Germany (Triathlon),
- one of the Europe's largest startup incubation and acceleration system (CC), France, representing the Deep Tech Talents initiative[1] of European Institute of Innovation and Technology (EIT);

and complemented by the Armenian AI research company YerevaNN,
will implement the system of mutually interrelated activities targeting systemic changes and lasting impact. In fact, the project will not only boost the career perspectives of the AI research talents in Georgia's academia and industry directly participating in the project activities, but will also contribute towards introducing European standards in science & innovation management and governance.

1.1. Objectives #@PRJ-OBJ-PO@#

Artificial Intelligence is one of the most transformative forces of our time, and is bound to alter the fabric of society. It presents a great opportunity to increase prosperity and growth, which Europe must strive to achieve. Over the last decade, major advances were realised due to the availability of vast amounts of digital data (e.g. through IoT, the Internet content), powerful computing architectures (including HPC and Distributed Computing), and advances in AI techniques such as machine (deep) learning. Major AI-enabled developments in autonomous vehicles, healthcare, home/service robots, education or cybersecurity are improving the quality of our lives every day. The latest disruptive developments in Generative AI (e.g. Large AI Models and services built on them) have even a greater potential. The EU has declared the strategic goal of consolidating the efforts of all European and partner countries to cease fully the opportunities AI technology brings for social and economic development. In 2018 all EU Member States and Norway signed a Declaration of cooperation on Artificial Intelligence, the document representing a consolidated commitment to work together, increase and integrate resources for R&I activities in this area. The European efforts to maintain the leadership in Trustworthy and Ethical AI resulted in the adoption of the EU AI Act (in power starting from August 2024), the world's first regulation regarding the use of AI-based products and services. The implementation of the AI Act will require coordination and synchronization not only in the field of legislation adaptation, but also in the field of R&I and standardization. Therefore, the further extension of consolidation efforts to countries acceding to the EU and/or associated with the Union (like Georgia) is an important political motivation for FORGE-AI.

Why Georgia? Georgia is the country with a clearly articulated European integration policy, seeking membership in NATO and having EU Candidate Country status (starting from December 2023), one of the most important cooperation partners in Caucasus and Western Asia Regions. The white-paper document "Guiding principles of the National Strategy of Georgia on Artificial Intelligence"[2] directly indicates the need for alignment of the national AI policies to those in the EU: "*Special attention is to be paid to the documents adopted*

[1] https://www.eitdeeptechtalent.eu
[2] https://btu.edu.ge/en/wef-content/guiding-principles-of-the-national-strategy-of-georgia-on-artificial-intelligence/

by the EU regarding introduction of artificial intelligence standards, especially, at in the context of full EU integration being the aim of Georgia's foreign policy. Convergence of the country's AI policy space with the European policies is an integral part of the process as well as making the steps which will support digital transformation of Georgia following the European norms". In 2024, **Georgia announced three new technological priorities, one of which is AI**. It is planned that Georgia's first-ever AI Strategy will be developed through interagency cooperation, with the process led by GITA. Moreover, GITA is now involved in a feasibility study regarding establishing an AI Excellence Centre in Georgia. As a similar plan is under discussion in Armenia, the contacts between AI professionals within the project will contribute to a regional coordination. FORGE-AI plans to contribute towards the AI Strategy development and implementation.

Georgia is a country of limited economic and human resources, especially those available in the area of Research and Innovation. In the 2023 Government AI Readiness Index, Georgia is ranked 99th globally with an overall score of 41.27, reflecting its performance across three pillars: Government (41.96), Technology Sector (30.33), and Data & Infrastructure (51.50). When compared to regional neighbours, Georgia ranks behind Turkey, which has an overall score of 60.51, Ukraine at 53.29, Armenia at 45.22, Azerbaijan at 48.15, and Moldova at 42.97. This comparison highlights that Georgia is trailing behind these countries in overall AI readiness, one of the goals of including a leading research company from Armenia is to improve the regional connections and benchmark the situation. Considering the current AI state of play in the country, it is important to take radical and effective steps to improve the global and regional AI competitiveness and ensure that Georgia is not left behind by the "AI revolution". This is exactly where the cooperation with the EU is critically important.

The key consortium members, GTU and DFKI, have a history of cooperation including the FP7 GEO-RECAP and running GAIN[3] (Georgian AI Networking Initiative, HEP Twinning) projects. The latter project included an extensive SWOT study of the national AI capabilities and opportunities for European integration, as well as networking activities centred around a joint research project in the field of multimodal Large AI models. The conclusions of the GAIN SWOT analysis were summarized in the Table 1.

Table 1. **Actions needed to enhance the R&I and Networking Capacity of Georgian AI community** (courtesy of the GAIN project, GA 101078950)

	Opportunities external positive	**Threats** external, negative
Strengths internal positive	Strength-Opportunity strategies **Building new Excellence in the field of AI** ● Capitalizing on the traditional strength in basic research extend the cooperation with European AI partners, including through mutual learning and knowledge circulation. ● To define and reinforce/develop strong *niche* competences with high complementarity opportunities (research "Smart Specialization Strategy"). ● Building on available competences of the staff and attracting young researchers with new competences to rapidly develop modern research capacities in AI (profile modernization). To reverse the negative demographical trend and bridge the gap between senior and young researchers through better career opportunities for the latter. ● Foster and support the entrepreneurship culture among young AI researchers. Offer them effective training and appealing cross-sector career development prospects ● Promote AI competences, available in academia and AI companies, to potential business partners	Strength-Threat strategies **Networking and internationalization** ● Increasing the visibility of the Georgian AI through the networking capacities of existing EU partners (DFKI, CERN, INRIA, etc.) to trigger new bilateral collaborations ● Building links to principal research institutions and industrial leaders of the EU for the development of consortia for participation in Horizon Europe and subsequent FPs. ● Improving research profiles of key scientists and rapidly preparing a new wave of research leaders capable of cross-sector career development and AI innovation. **Improving policy framework** ● Initiating the dialogue with national Education and Science authorities in order to put application-oriented AI high on the national political agenda. By using European examples and best practice of cooperation to improve the local support to this field in Georgia (innovation-oriented research funding instruments). ● To mitigate the threats of brain-drain and ageing by extending the opportunities for attractive career development, including through starting-up. Introduce new relevant funding instruments for that (cross-sector mobility grants, grants for innovation projects and starting-up)

[3] http://www.gain-twinning.eu/

	in Georgia and the region (South Caucasus, Turkey, Middle East)	• Support continuous capacity building activities in the field of innovation. Develop new financial instruments for that.
Weaknesses internal, negative	Weakness-Opportunity strategies **New capacities building** • Using internationalization to get access to modern European research expertise for rapid profile change • Using internalization, supporting cross-sector mobility and knowledge circulation to create better career prospects for young researchers ("train-and-retain" strategy) • To rapidly develop new competences in fundraising, commercialization and PR **Re-targeting cooperation strategy** • Capitalizing on existing partnerships to broaden the network in the EU to include industrial partners • By broadening the scope of cooperation to embrace academia and industry to make available new sources of R&I funding • Closer look at the region (neighbouring countries), especially on business opportunities for AI start-ups	Weakness-Threat strategies **Far-seeing employment/management strategy** • In case of worsening external/internal conditions use all resources to retain young research staff to prevent ageing of research community. Cross-sector cooperation and mobility (R&D for the industry, spinning-off, other forms of technology transfer) is the way to achieve that. • To reverse the brain-drain by creating attractive career opportunities in Georgia with competitive remuneration and internationalisation opportunities. **Funding diversification** • Optimization and concentration of available public funding on a limited set of priorities, creating private-public partnerships for resources mobilisation and targeting. • Internalization as a core activity for all research organizations • Commercialization of research results through IP marketing and starting-up • Diversification of budget involving private contracts.

Obviously, in the centre of the recommendations above is the need to swiftly and radically improve the career prospects for young AI researchers and, thanks to that, **attract and retain talents** in this area. AI is a very dynamic research field with enormous innovation potential, which makes it dependent on young talents with open and entrepreneurial mindsets, skills and knowledge allowing transforming research results into technologies for economy and society. Also, the analysis points out at the problem of inherited weakness of innovation helix in Georgia where the disconnect between academia and industry is stronger than in the EU in average. Despite the appearance of first AI startups, existing Governmental supporting mechanisms and generally favourable business environment (Georgia is ranked *second in the world* for "Start business" and seventh – for "Ease of doing business"[4]) the technology startup culture still needs further development. In this culture shift, the internalisation and cooperation with European partners shall play a central role as the country's internal resources and best practice base are insufficient.

In order to lay a foundation for the lasting and sustainable effect the project will also address one of the structural problems of the Georgian innovation support system. In fact, according to its mission, SRNSF funds scientific excellence, including academic mobility, with the focus on basic research. At the same time, GITA provides support to successful startups (e.g. seed capital grants). Therefore, the activities aimed at the transition from scientific activities to starting up (research entrepreneurship support and motivation, technology maturation and technology transfer, etc.) fall in-between and suffer from insufficient support. This is also one of the factors limiting cross-sector career opportunities for Georgian AI researchers and one of the areas where European experiences can play a key role.

Therefore, the **overall project objective** is to boost interoperability of careers for AI researchers and other R&I talents in the academic and non-academic sectors of Georgia and improve employability of AI R&I talents across sectors. By attaining this objective, the project aims to contribute to the general innovation-oriented shift in the Georgian AI R&I with sustainable progress firmly supported by the country's policies and financial commitments.

The project pursues the following operational objectives:

Table 2. **FORGE-AI Operational objectives**

Obj. 1 To strengthened AI R&I human capital base in Georgia with more entrepreneurial and better-trained researchers, innovators, research managers and/or other R&I talents, as well as to boost R&I support capacity in academic and non-academic organisations.

[4] https://archive.doingbusiness.org/en/rankings

Tangible Outcome: Structured, well-documented for replication and based on local needs Capacity Building programmes for young AI researchers and research managers, administrators and innovators.
Evaluation: KPIs: number of researchers trained (target value: 150), number of research managers and innovators trained (target value 40), number of innovative ideas pitched (target value: 10), coached and supported (target value: 4), training materials for courses granting micro-credentials (target value: training duration equivalent to 3-4 ECTS). Validation: Training events documentation; and verification by experts
Baseline: Existing training experiences and materials of ICARTI, Triathlon, CC and DFKI
Attainability: The existing long-term experiences of training providers.

Obj. 2 – To design, implement and evaluate cross-sector and cross-border secondment programme for Georgian AI R&I talents with the aim to boost their career development

Tangible Outcome: A cohort of Georgian AI R&I talents exposed to cross-sector international innovation practices, obtained experiences of pursuing research activities in distributed international teams with innovation focus. Documented, first-hand experiences in designing and implementing such mobility programmes.
Evaluation: KPIs: Number of researchers, managers and innovators taken part in secondments (target value: 25), volume of the programme in secondment/months (target value: 228 months), average satisfaction index of secondees (target value: 4,5 out of 5). Validation: Secondment programme documentation, post-programme surveys and interviews.
Baseline: Experiences of (industrial) secondments within EC MSCA actions (DFKI); research mobility of the GAIN project. Current researcher mobility programme funded by SRNSF.
Attainability: Successful completion of several MSCA projects at DFKI; positive and enthusiastic feedback of Georgian researchers stayed at DFKI (GAIN). Experiences of organizing mobility programmes in Georgia (SRNSF)

Obj. 3 – To collect and analyse the best European practices of supporting innovation and cross-sector cooperation, including boosting cross-sector career interoperability for AI R&I talents, and, on this basis, to initiate the adjustments in the national practices and policies

Tangible Outcome: Recommendations on innovation-oriented research for Georgian research organizations, which include adapted to national conditions best practice cases. White Paper "Cross-sector research careers: needs and supporting mechanisms" targeting policy-making level and calling to include cross-sector career interoperability funding instruments into the portfolio of SRNSF and GITA.
Evaluation: KPIs: number of working meetings with European policy-level organizations (target value: 3), number of policy-level documents developed and officially published (target value: 2). Validation: project documentation (reports), official publications on websites of SRNSF and GITA.
Baseline: Previous experiences of policy reforms in Georgia, including launches of new research and innovation funding programmes
Attainability: Both SRNSF and GITA are official Governmental agencies with the mission and **mandate** to support research and innovation, therefore they have all the means to attain the goal.

Obj. 4 – To raise awareness of the Georgian R&I capabilities in the field of AI in the EU; to extend the individual professional networks of Georgian AI R&I talents, thus supporting their career development; to promote the project and the Europe's support in Georgia

Tangible Outcome: Web and social media resources of the project. Significant and visible AI community event.
Evaluation: KPIs: number of Georgian AI researchers exposed to the project results (target value: 500), number of publications on the project activities (target value: 25), number of social media campaigns (target value: 2). Validation: Project documentation, web statistics; verification by experts.
Baseline: Well-established and relevant dissemination channels of all partners; existing awareness of EU-Georgia cooperation in R&I
Attainability: All project partners have extensive and lasting experiences of project-specific and general dissemination activities, as well as credible professional staff for that.

#§PRJ-OBJ-PO§#

1.2. Coordination and/or support measures and methodology #@CON-MET-CM@# #@COM-PLE-CP@#

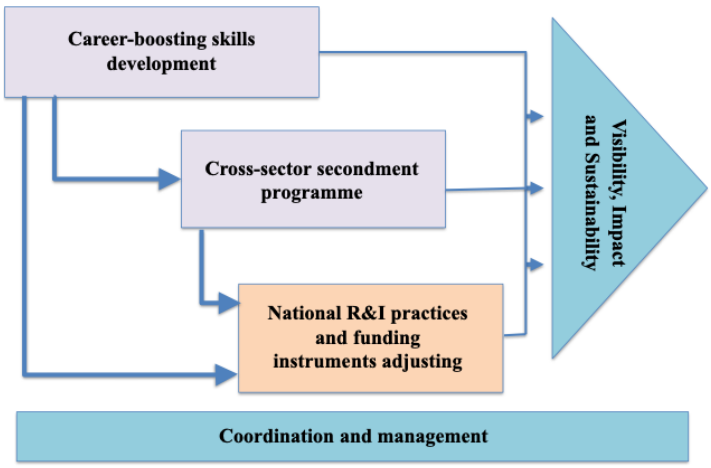
The project methodology has been designed to support the attainment of the overall project objective and to create favourable and sustainable enabling conditions for cross-sector career development for young AI researchers and other R&I talents, thus strengthening the national innovation system in this thematic area.

The project builds on the following premises and assumptions:

- Despite relatively good quality of education and basic research in the country, Georgia still does not enjoy fully the economic and social benefits of innovation. This can be observed in the area of AI: such AI-powered services, which are standard and routine for Europeans, like e.g. machine translation, voice assistants, chat bots, etc. either are not available or demonstrate poorer quality. There is a need to bridge existing research capabilities and urgent market needs through innovation. International, regional and in-country cross-sector research mobility and, enabled by it, technology transfer are one of the key remedies for the problem.
- The start-up culture is still in its initial development phase. The boost can be achieved by raising awareness about the practical ways of starting up, fostering entrepreneurial attitudes in (young) researchers and providing consulting and coaching support. As an important step in this process, the innovation skills development training tailored to the realities in the country is needed.
- Successful cross-sector research careers in Georgia are rare. The reasons for that are multifaceted, but one of them is the unpreparedness of researchers to working in the industrial environment, lack of knowledge in the field of companies' needs and processes. On the other hand, the practice of cooperation between high-tech companies and research performers is also underdeveloped. Success stories of cross-sector mobility and career development supporting bi-directional cooperation are needed.
- Despite historical, cultural and geographic closeness, the level of cooperation between the Georgian and Armenian AI academic and business communities does not correspond to the level of other ties.
- The Georgian Government and research organizations are still looking for optimal ways of fostering innovation. Establishment of GITA in 2014 with a number of AI startups supported by the agency, emergence of first technoparks, innovation centres and industrial labs marked a substantial progress in this process. At the same time, the support to cross-sector and cross-border career interoperability in the context of innovation is still very new in the country and requires further adjustments.

In order to address the abovementioned problems and provide support based on the European experiences and best practice the project methodology combines 3 phases:

- **Phase 1: Career-boosting innovation skills development**. Within this phase a representative and significant cohort of young AI researchers, research managers and innovators will be trained in skills and competences critical for career interoperability and developing innovation support services in RTOs and high-tech companies. In addition to that, the training on the EU AI Act, as an important competence for industrial career development, will be provided. The skills and competences acquired on this phase will lay a foundation to the success in implementing cross-sector secondments.



- **Phase 2: Cross-sector secondments.** The secondment programme is designed to develop further the skills and competences of training programmes' selected participants, as well as to widen the career prospects and networking opportunities for them. The programme will enable the Georgian AI R&I talents to work for significant periods of time in European organizations, which will also facilitate internalisation of the Georgian AI research community and its partnering with European peers. It is also expected that

the experiences of the programme will generate the knowledge base on how to design and implement such programmes in the future.

- **Phase 3: Innovation policies and practices adjustment**. The Georgian consortium members, led by SRNSF and GITA, will collect best practice and experiences throughout Phase 1 and Phase 2 to incorporate them into their daily activities. SRNSF and GITA, the natural multipliers in the Georgian R&I system, will disseminate the practice on the system level. Moreover, the obtained experiences will allow both agencies to incorporate the elements of activities piloted by the project into the future funding programmes, thus closing existing gaps in innovation support.

1.2.1 Career boosting skills development

The training programme includes 3 components:

- Innovation skills training for **AI researchers** coming predominantly from public RTOs (Universities, research institutes associated with Universities, other research organizations), but also from companies – to attend the modules of interest;
- Innovation support training for **R&I managers and administrators** from academia, managerial staff of companies from the area of AI-based software development and services (e.g. startups), as well as staff of national R&I agencies;
- **EU AI Act training** for all target groups above. The EU AI Act is the world's first regulation regarding the use of AI-based systems, which is in force as of August 2024 and has a global impact. In fact, it also impacts on the way of developing AI-based systems and doing research in this area. The solid knowledge about the risk-based classification of AI systems, certification process for high risk solutions, roles, responsibilities and liabilities of all stakeholders is critical for successful cross-sector career development.

In the pre-phase, the project will implement the training needs analysis by interviewing a representative set of stakeholders in Georgia, ICARTI is in charge. The results of that will be presented during the online programme design workshop (month 2), which will allow the training providers (DFKI, Triathlon, CC, ICARTI) to adjust and finetune the training content and methodology to the local needs.

The training programmes will be promoted nationally and regionally by utilizing channels of SRNSF, GITA, GAIA, and other partner networks. The goal will be to attract a diverse pool of AI researchers and other R&I talents. Open registration and a rigorous selection process will aim to enrol at least 60 participants face-to-face (at least 55 of them from Georgia), ensuring a representative cohort from various disciplines (core AI, adjacent areas such as Data Sciences, Robotics, areas with potential for AI applications). Online participation option will be provided to extend the audience beyond the target face-to-face attendance with the cap of 150 in total. Also, the training sessions will be recorded and made available afterwards.

Training for research talents

The training is organized in 2 face-to-face waves bridged by the series of webinars and complemented by a Deep Dive coaching stage starting as soon as possible and stretching throughout the first half of the project and overlapping with the secondment programme. It is expected that all potential secondees will take part in training.

First wave of workshops (month 6). Goal: To introduce participants to the foundational elements of innovation and entrepreneurship, with a focus on practical skills and strategic thinking. Tentative topics:

- ***From an idea to a product***: ***Design Thinking Workshops.*** Content: (1) Innovation cycle, Double-Diamond Design Thinking methodology, User-Centered Design and co-creation; (2) Synthesis - Define Problem Statements: Participants will learn how to synthesize research findings into clear, actionable problem statements; (3) Validation: Engage in validation exercises to test the feasibility and relevance of their problem statements and potential IP strategies against real-world scenarios; (4)Prototyping**:** Develop low-fidelity prototypes of IP management plans or frameworks, allowing participants to visualize and iterate on their strategies in a tangible, interactive format; (5) Iteration/Feedback**:** Use feedback loops to refine IP strategies.
- ***Intellectual Property Management: Strategies and Real-World Examples.*** Content: This session will

emphasize the critical role of intellectual property (IP) in the innovation process and provide strategies for managing IP effectively throughout various stages of product development. Special attention will be paid to AI- and open-source software specific aspects of IP management.

- ***Technology transfer. IP licencing and spinning-off.*** Content: Goals and types of technology transfer. Classification of licences, licensing for software including open-source, smart licensing strategy. Steps of spinning off, knowledge transfer agreements, valuation of IP, etc.
- ***Start-up survival toolkit: what to consider for your start-up.*** Content: Optimal conditions and timing for spinning-off. Team and shareholder structure. Optimal legal form. Registration process. Initial finances.

Bridging online phase (webinars). Goal: To bridge the foundational learning from the first face-to-face session and prepare participants for the next phase of the training by expanding on concepts of innovation and marketing through three online sessions (webinar-like, incl. Q&A and troubleshooting).

- ***From Invention to Market.*** Objective: Understand the journey from a technological invention to a market-ready innovation. Content: Explore the steps involved in transforming a technological breakthrough into a commercial product. Focus on understanding market needs, customer validation, and the innovation adoption curve. Outcome: simple Business Model Canvas.
- ***Marketing Fundamentals: Identifying Pain Points and Developing Consumer Personae.***
- ***Market Validation Techniques.***

Second wave of workshops (month 15-18). To focus on entrepreneurship fundamentals and practical skills needed to take a product to market. To finalize the pre-training of secondees.

- ***Entrepreneurship Fundamentals. Crafting a Compelling Pitch Deck.*** These 2 workshops will provide a deep dive into the essentials of entrepreneurship, focusing on the development of a successful pitch deck. A pitch deck is a concise, 20-slide presentation designed to give a short summary of your company, business plan, and start-up vision. The practical part will include the development of pitches in working groups and a pitching session.

Deep Dive Coaching. Four best pitches will be selected and the working groups will be involved in online in-depth coaching, increasing the likelihood of their ideas evolving into newly founded companies. This stage will consist of 5 to 6 days of intensive consulting and mentorship to help these groups refine their business models and advance their products from Proof of Concept (POC) to Minimum Viable Product (MVP). Where possible, the secondments will be used to intensify coaching and facilitate the business development. Expected Outcomes of Deep Dive Stage:

- **MVP Development:** Each group will strive to leave with a fully developed MVP that is ready for market testing and investor pitches
- **Investor-Ready Business Plans:** Creation of robust business plans and financial models that can attract early-stage investment.
- **Enhanced Skills and Confidence:** Participants will gain deeper insights and experience in moving from ideation to execution, increasing their confidence and ability to succeed in the entrepreneurial landscape.

Participants completing the full programme will receive *micro-credentials in the form of digital badges* issued by GTU and compliant with the European standards. These badges will certify the skills and knowledge gained during the training, enhancing participants' professional profiles.

Training for research and innovation managers

Training session overview

- **Entrepreneurship and innovation support services: European best practice** (Triathlon, CC, GITA). The European partners will provide a comprehensive overview of entrepreneurship and innovation supporting services in academic (Triathlon) and business (CC) environments (several decades of experience). GITA will complement it with the overview of instruments/services available in Georgia.
- **Designing an innovation project: from TRL5 to TRL8** (DFKI, ICARTI). As DFKI is a founding members of several KICs of European Institute of Innovation and Technology (EIT Digital, Manufacturing, also Health), the EIT methodology of designing innovation projects will be presented. The training will help

the participants to organize technology maturation activities, thus bridging the gap between basic research results and application-oriented technology. During the workshop's follow-up phase, the participants will be asked to prepare a pitch for a potential innovation project. The pitch session will be organized later in the project to facilitate the secondees selection activities.

- **European and Georgian funding instruments supporting cross-sector R&I careers** (DFKI, GITA). The goal is to raise awareness of and increase success chances of participation in such innovation-related European funding schemes as MSCA (Industrial) Doctoral Networks, Postdoctoral Fellowship, EIC Transition/Accelerator (Georgia is an eligible country). Examples of successful proposals will be analysed. GITA will contribute to training with the presentation of its own funding instruments.
- **Smart Investment Strategy for startups** (GITA, Triathlon). During the workshop the business valuation methodology, factors defining investor attractiveness, as well as investment readiness of companies, will be presented. Types of investors/investments and their goals, optimal investment strategies for technology startups will be discussed. The participants will be asked to present their investment cases.

Similarly to research talents training, granting digital badges upon the programme completion will be done.

Training on EU AI Act

The target group for this training activity will include AI R&I talents representing both academia and industry. The importance of raising awareness of the new EU regulation on the use of Artificial Intelligence is high as this regulation will also have a direct impact on applied research and innovation by defining the framework and procedures for bringing innovative technologies to the market. Therefore, solid knowledge in this area will enable R&I talents from academia to carry out research targeting applications with a market potential. At the same time, the training will help researchers and managers of technology-intensive AI companies to integrate the measures necessary for the EU AI Act compliance into their R&I activities.

The training will be organized in 2 steps:

1. Face-to-face workshop right before the start of the secondment programme to involve also all secondees. In this workshop led by DFKI the trainees will get information about the AI risk-based principles underlying the approach to AI systems classification, roles and responsibilities of stakeholders involved in the life cycle of AI-based systems, basics of AI-based software certification and relevant standards, as well as how to integrate "AI Act compliance" into the research and technology development activities.
2. Online workshop close to the end of the project to present the available European practice on AI Act implementation (e.g. European AI Trust Label and related certification process, requirements of notified bodies, practice of designing scientific studies aimed at technology validation in the context of certification, etc.). **Importantly,** the workshop will also include the presentation of relevant Georgian/Armenian experts with the information on the status-quo of EU AI Act compliance in the region and its impact on science and economy.

The 1st workshop will allow the secondees to include the aspects related to EU AI Act into their Secondment Plans and, after the completion of secondments, to contribute to the second workshop with practical examples and cases.

1.2.2 Cross-sector secondment programme

The goals of the project secondment programme are two-folds:

- **Short term:** *to boost the career opportunities for a representative cohort of young Georgian AI R&I talents* by enabling cross-sector and cross-border working experiences in European organizations with relevant profiles; by extending their professional networks; by developing new skills and competences supporting multi-optional career development.
- **Long term:** *to create first-hand experiences of organizing and implementing cross-sector and cross-border secondment (mobility) programmes* for including such activities into the national research support and facilitation practices in the future.

The planned secondments are in line with the rules of the call. The principles of the secondment programme design are as follows:

1. **Representative target group.** The talents to be selected for secondments will represent all target groups

the project addresses: researchers from academia and industry (14 talents), research managers of academic organizations and start-up companies (7 talents), research administrators representing national funding agencies (4 talents). The focus will be on researchers, their secondment/months compose more than 43% of the programme.

2. **Transparency and inclusion**. The selection procedure will be open and based on merits, the fairness and inclusiveness will be monitored and ensured. The Consortium selection panel will review each candidate to make sure that the secondment has a significant impact on personal career development.
3. **Goal-oriented approach**. Each secondment will have a concrete goal linked to personal career development plans, each secondee will be integrated into the hosting team with clearly defined tasks and expected outcomes, *each secondee will be supervised for the entire stay* by clearly identified supervisors representing sending and hosting organizations. Placing of secondees inside hosting organizations and business entities (the cases of European startups from business incubators of Triathlon and CC) will be based on the results of *matching the individual goals of a secondee and a profile of hosting team*. This matching will be done within the selection process, the result will be agreed with all stakeholders and all necessary arrangements will be completed before the secondment starts.
4. **Cross-sector/cross-border secondments as a priority**. Vast majority of secondments fulfil this criterion. In 24 out of 25 cases secondments are both cross-sector and cross-border (22 to the EU and 2 to Armenia) and in 1 case – cross-border secondment of industrial researcher from Georgia to a European company to obtain the experiences of international secondments for research capacity building and business partnership.
5. **Supporting environment and effective reintegration of secondees.** As the secondees will spend significant periods of time outside of their country and their organizations, the project includes several measures supporting them during secondments. First of all, the financial arrangements are done in compliance with the living standards in hosting countries. Both sending and hosting organizations will be responsible for timely visa and other organizational arrangements. The sending organizations will be in charge of supporting secondees in their research/training activities (mobility inside Europe/region for e.g. attending events; other unavoidable research costs). The coordinator will appoint the *secondees ombudsperson*, the manager responsible for supporting secondees in case any needs emerge. When it comes to reintegration, the package of documents to be developed before the start of secondment (actually, the basis for secondment granting decision of the Consortium selection panel) will include *the institutional commitment letter* , in which the sending organization will indicate the reintegration support measures, such as guaranteed employment for the period of secondment and at least one year after its completion; potential promotion opportunities; material stimuli; etc. All secondees upon their return will be invited to report whether or not the commitments of sending organizations are fulfilled. All cases of complains will be discussed by the Project Coordination Committee to identify the reasons and take corrective measures wherever possible (e.g. direct communication with the management of sending organizations). An additional role in the secondees' reintegration will play the FORGE-AI Alumni and GAIA, as both will extend professional networking opportunities for community reintegration.
6. **Sustainability.** The sustainability of the secondment programme outcomes will be ensured through collecting the best/bad practice associated with each secondment. This will be achieved by implementing impact assessment study during and after secondments (leader GITA), the study will include surveys, individual interviews and reporting. The analytical analysis of collected data will allow drawing generic conclusions and using them for policy development, which will support the integration of cross-sector/ cross-border activities in R&I practices in Georgia. Also, the project plans to initiate the FORGE-AI Alumni, the activity allowing extending the innovation community building impact of the project long beyond its end.

The secondment plan is presented in Table 3. The column "Comments" gives a tentative focus of each secondment. The estimation of secondment costs have been done on the basis of the following:

- Each secondee will get travel support (estimated costs in range 750 - 790 euro per secondment). If during

the secondment the need to travel (e.g. conference attendance, research visit, etc.) emerges and the anticipated costs exceed the initial sum, the sending organization will be in charge of costs covering.

- For each month of secondment a secondee will receive the allowance (estimated costs in range 1400 - 1700 euro per secondment) to cover accommodation and per diems (in line with national standards).
- The regular salary of the secondee (in the range of 2,300-2,500 euro) will be provided by the sending organization. In all cases when secondees have families and other similar commitments at home, the sending organizations will consider additional support.
- The costs associated with the secondment programme implementation (travel costs, costs of stay and salaries of secondees allocated to the Georgian sending organizations) are estimated as 888,800 euro, which represent more than 32% of the total project costs.

1.2.3 Innovation policies and practices adjustment

The goal of the activities integrated under this subheading is to contribute to the ongoing process of S&I system reforms in Georgia aimed at turning Georgia into an innovation-driven country with modern economy and public services. The specific project contribution will concern with obtaining practical experiences and measuring impact of activities aimed at enabling young R&I talents to pursue cross-sector career paths and, thus, facilitate knowledge circulation as a basis for innovation. Additionally, the networking and mutual learning activities with major European multipliers in the area of AI innovation (ADRA, EIT, CLAIRE) will support the national AI Strategy development.

The following activities will contribute to this goal attainment:

- *Best/bad practice and impact assessment* of both innovation skills training programme and secondment programme. Direct participation of the staff of SRNSF and GITA in the programme design and implementation, special impact assessment study, secondments of their staff members in European innovation multiplier organizations will contribute to collecting the body of knowledge to be used for policy reforms.
- *Direct networking with major European AI innovation multipliers,* such as ADRA Association, EIT with its Deep Tech Talents initiative, CLAIRE. The set of meetings and joint workshops will allow to establish direct contacts between the leadership of Georgian AI R&I system and European peers, learn the best practice and find the optimal ways of aligning the Georgian innovation support policies, instruments and practices with those in Europe.
- *Development and promotion of practical Recommendations* regarding the introduction of cross-sector and cross-border career boosting activities piloted throughout the project into research practices in Georgia. Major focus will be on PhD/MSc studies as a basis for fostering new generations of researchers and innovators. For instance, the heads of PhD programmes and research departments from all Universities of Georgia will be invited to take part in the capacity building programme, their feedback will be important to find practically implementable and effective ways of integrating such training into the training component of PhD/MSc programmes within existing educational standards. SRNSF, as foundation associated with the Ministry of Education, will channel the project outcomes to the relevant parts of the Ministry.
- *Initiating the policy reforms* aiming at adjusting the innovation facilitation framework in Georgia. Both SRNSF and GITA will identify the opportunities for integrating funding instruments supporting cross-sector cross-border career development for R&I talents into their portfolios. In addition to that, other relevant opportunities will be identified to initiate a broader reform (e.g. adjustments in education standards, new certified academic and training programmes, national innovation helix building initiatives, etc.). The concise and structured presentation of the findings will be provided as a White Paper style document; SRNSF and GITA, being parts of the Government, will disseminate the document to relevant stakeholders in the policy-making process.

1.2.4 Open Science and Data Management

Although FORGE-AI **is not** directly aimed at generating scientific results and other scientific outputs (e.g. training datasets, software, etc.), the aspects of Open Science approach and related Data management practices

will be touched upon during the Career boosting skills development programme implementation. Both target groups (researchers and research managers) will be exposed to the open science principles during the training on IP generation and protection. Moreover, all potential secondees will be asked to highlight in the Secondment Plans how the principles of Open Science will be implemented (further studied) during their secondments. The subheading on Open Science and Data Management will be included into the Secondment Report template.

Within the project's impact assessment activities the consortium will collect several datasets, for instance training feedback questionnaires, secondee survey questionnaires, interview summaries, secondment reports, etc. Although, it is planned that the data will be used solely for the project purposes and will not be shared with external entities, in all cases the requirements of GDPR will be respected and implemented (e.g. informed consent, anonymisation/pseudonymisation, life cycle of data definition, etc.). As the Georgian personal data protection regulation is compliant with the GDPR principles, the universal applicability of those will be ensured. The plans regarding data collection and resulting datasets will be provided in the Data Management Plan.

Table 3 – **Secondments between beneficiaries**

Talents	Category of staff to be sent on secondment	Sending Institution				Hosting Institution				Duration (months)	Topics
		Acronym	Sector	Country	WC/ nWC	Acronym	Sector	Country	WC/ nWC		
1	Admin	SRNSF	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	6	RTO-based innovation service
2	Admin	SRNSF	Non-academic	GE	WC	Triathlon	Academic	DE	nWC	6	University-based innovation service
3	Admin	GITA	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	6	RTO-based innovation service
4	Admin	GITA	Non-academic	GE	WC	CC	Non-academic	FR	nWC	6	Business incubators operation
5	Innovator	DAL	Non-academic	GE	WC	CC	Non-academic	FR	nWC	6	Sustainability of startup, investment
6	Innovator	Helio.AI	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	6	Technology scouting, networking
7	Innovator	AILab	Non-academic	GE	WC	Triathlon	Academic	DE	nWC	6	Sustainability of startup, investment
8	Researcher	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	Triathlon*	Non-academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in business environment
9	Researcher	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	Triathlon*	Non-academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in business environment
10	Researcher	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	CC*	Non-academic	FR	nWC	12	Research in business environment
11	Researcher	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	CC*	Non-academic	FR	nWC	12	Research in business environment
12	Researcher	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	Triathlon*	Non-academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in business environment
13	Researcher	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	Triathlon*	Non-academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in business environment
14	Researcher	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	CC*	Non-academic	FR	nWC	12	Research in business environment
15	Researcher	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	CC*	Non-academic	FR	nWC	12	Research in business environment
16	Researcher	DAL	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in RTO, research skills
17	Researcher	Helio.AI	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in RTO, research skills
18	Researcher	AILab	Non-academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	12	Research in RTO, research skills
19	Researcher	DAL	Non-academic	GE	WC	Triathlon*	Non-academic	DE	nWC	12	Joint technology development
20	Manager	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	6	RTO-based innovation service
21	Manager	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	Triathlon	Academic	DE	nWC	6	University-based innovation service
22	Manager	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	CC	Non-academic	FR	nWC	6	Startup facilitation
23	Manager	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	DFKI	Academic	DE	nWC	6	RTO-based innovation service
24	Researcher	GTU	Academic	GE	WC	YNN	Non-academic	AM	WC	12	To pilot regional secondments
25	Researcher	TSU	Academic	GE	WC	YNN	Non-academic	AM	WC	6	To pilot regional secondments

(*) marked placements with residents of Startup Business Incubators run by Triathlon and CC.

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2. Impact

2.1 Project's pathways towards impact

2.1.1 Strategic impact

FORGE-AI has been designed as a project delivering the impact on the Georgian R&I system as a whole, as well as a project of regional importance. Despite the fact that the project is directly focused on the area of AI, the principle outcomes will have their relevance and applicability to other areas of R&I. AI, being a fundamental enabling technology, has a strategic importance to Georgia and has been declared as one of priorities for the years to come, therefore it has been chosen as a thematic domain for piloting the new innovation-supporting instruments with a dual goal:

- Mid-term: to boost the innovation in the area of application-oriented AI and to radically speed up the uptake of AI-based technologies in economy and public services. The project will train a significant cohort of Georgian AI researchers, managers and innovators: as the AI community is relatively small, the project plans to directly address by its training measures at least 20% of all AI specialists in Georgia. Moreover, 25 researchers, managers and innovators will be involved in secondments, which will additionally result in a group of the future AI R&I leaders exposed to the European way of doing research and innovation, equipped with in-depth professional cross-sector competences and well-networked with European and regional partners. All these outcomes will allow to expect very practical outcomes (new applied research directions, new AI startups, new/improved AI products/services put on the market, etc.) already at the end of the project or shortly after its completion.
- Long-term: to multiply the impact of innovation-supporting activities piloted within the project to the entire AI community and other application-oriented research area, thus steadily facilitating the transition of the Georgian R&I system towards a new model in line with the EU trends in this field. Direct and active participation of the Governmental R&I funders, agenda-setting research performers and educators, ambassadors of emerging high-tech industry, research NGOs, creates favourable conditions for attaining this goal. It is expected that the project will influence several strategic initiatives in planning:
    - Strengthening of innovation-related training measures in all publicly supported programmes aimed at educating and training qualified research personnel. Significant improvement of innovation training measures supported by GITA.
    - Integration of cross-sector aspect into the mobility programme supported by the Government (SRNSF). First calls with such adjustments to be published shortly after the project end.
    - Potentially, emergence of funding opportunities directly supporting technology transfer from academia to industry through joint research and mobility (e.g. calls for innovation projects similar in purpose to those Innovation Actions of the EU's HEP, DEP or EIT programmes)

At pointed out in section 1.1, Georgia is a small country with limited resources, therefore even one single project of that size has a potential to make a real difference. The project will focus on young AI talents (professionals of age 25-30, up to 35 as an exception) - this priority will be observed while inviting the participants for training and will be a selection criterion for secondments. This approach allows to provide a push to the selected AI talents right at the beginning of their professional life thus enabling them to pursue a multi-optional career path. Finally, FORGE-AI will invest in young R&I leaders who will shape the future of Georgian science, education and industry with the European vector.

2.1.2 Contribution to expected outcomes

The project will make the contribution to the following expected outcomes:

- *Strengthened R&I human capital base in Widening countries with more entrepreneurial and better-trained researchers, innovators, research managers and/or other R&I talents.* Here, the project will contribute by training at least 150 AI R&I talents in Georgia and Armenia on different aspects of research entrepreneurship and innovation. Moreover, the project will improve innovation-related training aspects in regular PhD and MSc programmes
- *Boosted R&I support capacity in academic and non-academic organisations.* The training programme

will involve at least 40 research managers from academia and non-academic organizations. Moreover, 11 managers and innovators will be on secondments in Europe (66 secondment/months).

- *A more balanced geographical and cross-sectoral talent circulation.* The project deliberately plans predominantly Georgia-EU secondments (only 2 secondments will be inside the region, Armenia) as they will have a strong impact on the Georgian AI professionals. Still, the project will pilot the practice of cross-sectoral talent circulation in all cases. This will be a first experience of that kind in Georgia.
- *Increased access for private entities to public R&I institutions, including R&I infrastructures and their know-how across Europe and beyond.* All research secondments from AI startups will allow the industrial AI talents from Georgia to access world-class research expertise (DFKI), computing and data infrastructure. For instance, the secondment from AILab to DFKI will contribute to the Georgian LLM training and finetuning using the DFKI's High Performance Computing (HPC) capabilities.
- *Increased excellence of the research performing organisation in Widening countries.* All participating startups are active in the area of Natural Language Processing (NLP), they will get access to the best European expertise (DFKI, Saarland University – Triathlon). But, also, 2 secondments in Armenia will serve the purpose of establishing direct links between leading Universities and regional business partners.
- *A more structured and impactful collaboration between the academic and non-academic sectors.* The project pilots several cooperative academia-industry activities and involves principle multipliers in this process as co-creators and active participants. As a result, the project plans to contribute towards establishing better framework conditions for cross-sector cooperation.
- *Increased research, entrepreneurial and other transferable skills for the R&I talents exchange in the action.* As indicated above, the project will directly contribute to improving research, entrepreneurial and other transferable skills for at least 20% of Georgian AI R&I talents (+ several Armenian AI talents). Indirectly, through the dissemination and exploitation activities, the entire R&I system will benefit.
- *Improved employability and sustainable career prospects for R&I talents within the academic and non-academic sectors.* Both training and secondment programmes are aimed at building competences critical for successful cross-sector careers. First-hand cross-sector experiences and knowledge of requirements will be an asset for all participants, thus improving their attractiveness to potential employers in all sectors. We also expect that the networks created thanks to the project will contribute to better employment prospects.

2.1.3 Key performance indicators

Number	Key Performance Indicators	Target for the end of project
	Innovation capacity building	
1	Number of researchers trained (f2f and online)	>150
2	Number of research managers and innovators trained	>40
3	Number of innovative ideas pitched	10
4	Number of innovative ideas coached and supported (Deep dive)	4
5	Volume of training materials for courses with micro-credentials (ECTS credits)	Equiv. 3-4
6	Number of self-containing training modules developed and piloted	>15
7	Average satisfaction index of course participants (1-5)	>4,5
	Cross-sector mobility	
1	Number of R&I talents on cross-sector cross-border secondments	25
2	Overall volume of the secondment programme (in secondment/months)	228
3	Number of joint publications resulting from secondment projects	>15
4	Number of products/services developed/improved as a result of secondments	>10
5	Number of technologies resulting from the project secondments (posters or demonstrators) exhibited at Industrial Exhibition	>10

6	Average satisfaction index of secondees (1-5)	>4,5
Dissemination and Sustainability		
1	Number of University/RTO research departments involved and reached	>30
2	Number of policy briefings and presentations of White Paper	>5
3	Number of visible R&I events organized by the project	3
4	Initial FORGE-AI Alumni registration	>100
5	Number of new startups coached through the project	2
6	Number of European innovation project proposals resulting from coaching on innovation instruments	2

2.2 Measures to maximize impact - Dissemination, exploitation and communication

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The project dissemination and communication activities are designed to maximally contribute to attaining the overall project goal – to boost interoperability of careers for AI researchers and other R&I talents in the academic and non-academic sectors of Georgia and improve employability of AI R&I talents across sectors. Therefore, the project dissemination will be focused on spreading the results obtained through innovation skills training programme design, implementation and evaluation, as well as collected through the secondment programme and materialized in policy-level outcomes.

The project's dissemination and communication activities will address the following target groups:

- Primary target: Georgian researchers and research bodies in the field of AI (and broader – the entire research community of Georgia and Armenia). The project will employ the most natural and effective dissemination channels for this target group: direct engagement with multipliers: research managements and administrations, conferences and workshops, publications in research journals and web resources, research training activities, etc. – all what allows to reach every person involved in research activities.
- European AI research community, both academia and industry. The goal will be to promote Georgian AI capabilities as a reliable and capable partner for R&I activities on the European level. Focus will be on the pockets of research excellence and unique research resources Georgian AI community can offer (e.g. access to language resources and other datasets, specific expertise in NLP for low-resourced languages, geo-spatial datasets, etc.). The dissemination capacities of DFKI and its networking partners in Europe will be employed.
- R&I policy bodies and multipliers. The goal will be to upscale the project outcomes to the national and, where possible, regional level in order to incorporate firmly the practices facilitating the interoperability of research careers into the entire R&I system. Where possible, it will be done within the existing regulation by promoting the project outcomes to multipliers (e.g. research departments and research institutes of all Universities, PhD/MSc programmes coordinators, industrial associations and clusters, etc.). At the same time, the project will take an effort to improve the regulatory and support framework by channelling the call for reforms to the policy level and adjusting national funding instruments.
- General public in the EU and South Caucasus. The project will promote the benefits and added value of the European R&I cooperation in the field of AI, highlighting the impact on quality of life in Europe and South Caucasus, as well as the impact on other key policies (e.g. European integration policy of Georgia).

Dissemination and exploitation of results

Traditional Dissemination

At the beginning of the project the consortium will develop the detailed Dissemination Plan, which will describe the set of dissemination assets and dissemination activities to be implemented within the 3-year project life time bringing together the following pieces of information:

- Major project outcomes in their evolution (e.g. training materials, analytical evaluation data on the secondment programme, policy-level materials, etc.) – "what to disseminate", with their dissemination-relevant characteristics in order to match it with the existing dissemination opportunities
- Major dissemination opportunities (conferences, journals, social media, Open Access databases, special

issues, etc.) with the relevant timing matching the availability of research results – "where to disseminate".

- Available resources (e.g. travel budgets of the partners, dissemination materials) to define the scope of the efforts and maximize the impact within the plausible budgetary framework.

The implementation of the Plan and its adjustment will be done on the annual basis; the reports about the dissemination will be integrated with the project progress reports.
The major dissemination and communication related KPIs are below. Here it is necessary to underline that the goal will be, first of all, *to address the Georgian research community*, thus the planning will make the priority presentations at the Georgian and regional events with high reputation and networking opportunities. When it comes to publications, the team will concentrate on the opportunities with the maximal impact factor and widest attendance. When it comes to Europe, the consortium will be predominantly focus on direct dissemination to major networking partners and projects capitalising on the capacities of the EU consortium members. For instance, DFKI will be responsible for engaging with major European AI-related networks such as ADRA, CLAIRE, AIM-NET, ELLIS, while Triathlon and CC will address the innovation-related networks like EIT (e.g. Deep Tech Talents Initiative).

Event-based dissemination to Research and Society

The project will organize the set of dissemination events aimed at presenting the project results and, indirectly, promoting the principles of cross-sector research career interoperability enabling knowledge circulation. The following will be organized as an integral part of the Scientific Excellence and Networking Capacity Building programme:

- The research symposium "EU-Georgia cooperation in Artificial Intelligence: industrial track" will be organized in the EU (tentatively, in Saarbruecken, Germany, hosted by DFKI and Triathlon) around the middle of the 12-monthly secondments wave, when all secondees are already well-integrated into their hosting teams and have clear roadmaps for their research/training work during secondments. As geographically Saarbruecken is located close to Paris (less than 2 hours by train), the participation of the secondees from France will be ensured. The event will host the presentations of all secondment projects with target results, keynotes of leading scientists, as well as the Industrial Panel discussion. The event will also involve Armenian colleagues from YNN, thus giving a regional perspective too.
- Final project conference with the tentative title "Georgian Artificial Intelligence Research and Innovation: European path" and organized in Tbilisi (Georgia). GAIA and GTU will lead the organization building on the previous experiences of organizing similar scale events. A high visibility R&I event showcasing the project results (e.g. most successful secondment projects) and promoting EU-Georgia cooperation in the field of AI across sectors. In order to attract quality attendance the consortium will make the following arrangements
    - The Conference will be organized under auspices of the Georgian Government (SRNSF, GITA)
    - 3-4 leading top-level European experts representing academia and industry will be invited as keynote speakers
    - The regional track will be coordinated by YNN bringing Armenian stakeholders. Potential topic for the trach: Georgia-Armenia cooperation in AI.
    - Conference participation will be free, as well as the provided publication opportunity.

  The local team will mobilize resources to increase the impact of the event by the following:
    - Policy level visibility will be ensured by organizing an AI R&I Policy Panel with the participation of the representatives of Government, CLAIRE, ADRA, other relevant stakeholders.
    - Attached Industrial and Innovation Exhibition with the participation of regional and European AI startups presenting innovative added value products and services, AI technologies, etc.
- Dissemination through training events the project organises. It is planned that the target audience (including the online component) will reach 150-200 participants well-representing the Georgian and regional AI R&I community. Moreover, the involvement of research managers and

administrators (multipliers) will also contribute to widening the outreach.

Exploitation

As a main exploitable result, the project will deliver the set of training modules linked into a coherent training programme covering the full spectrum of innovation-related topics. In order to ensure the opportunities for the training materials re-use and enable the replication of training measures in different context, the following will be implemented:

- All training modules will be developed in English as self-containing educational units (clear entry requirements and target competences, embedded transparent formative and summative quality assurance mechanism, etc.), which will make possible various scenarios of exploitation: whole programme replication; unbundling the programme and replication of certain modules on demand; integration of certain modules with other educational and training programmes (e.g. mainstream degree-oriented programmes, PhD training, reskilling/upskilling, etc.). This will also enable granting micro-credentials as a result of completion. *The plan is that GTU, supported by ICARTI, will integrate the innovation skills development training granting micro-credentials into its regular educational offer within the life time of the project.*
- Proper documentation and organization of materials in a searchable format for free online access. This will allow the uptake by third-party training/education providers.
- Promotion in Georgia and abroad (e.g. in Armenia) to stimulate uptake. The Recommendations on cross-sector interoperability of research careers to be developed and distributed to all public and private research organizations in the country will explicitly recommend the inclusion of innovation-related topics to researcher training programmes also pointing at the project's training materials as one of the potential sources of information.

When it comes to the secondment programme, all Secondment Plans to be developed will have to include the quantifiable information on the planned results, as well as the information on the results' exploitation. The Secondment reports template will also include the description of potential exploitation strategies.

Communication activities

In contrast to dissemination, the project communication activities will target more general audience and contain the information with more socioeconomic focus. The goal will be to raise the awareness of FORGE-AI and promote the project, as well as to promote research-driven innovation as a country's strategic priority. The project will employ traditional PR tools including

1. ***Online Communication*** The consortium intends to set up and maintain the FORGE-AI web platform, both throughout the project, as well as for at least a period of five years after the project's end; through the public area of the FORGE-AI web platform, public information will be disseminated, e.g., access to training materials, public deliverables, news, etc. In addition, the web platform will include a private area for the distribution of restricted information amongst the consortium members and for the management (MS Teams based channel). Furthermore, the consortium will also engage the utilization of social media for the dissemination of FORGE-AI. Everything on the public area of the FORGE-AI website can be liked and shared via Facebook and LinkedIn in order to enable the best user experience. The respective social media micro-sites will be established to spread special target-group tailored information from the FORGE-AI project to the users of these platforms and direct them to the FORGE-AI website. The consortium will also examine the distribution of multimedia material through YouTube, which will include a promotional video of the project. In addition to that, the project will support the development and maintenance of the web platform (website + social media) of the FORGE-AI Alumni.
2. ***Non-Electronic Communication*** This channel includes classical means of knowledge transfer such as leaflets, brochures and articles in magazines, publications in broadcast media and business papers focusing on the promotion of the project for general public, policy makers, businesses, NGOs, etc.
3. ***Interactive Communication*** This will offer a chance for personal interaction in academic, professional and socio-economic conferences and workshops, Georgia's and EU's organized events, trade fairs and exhibitions. It is intended for target groups with a high level of information need and involvement and provides information tailored to highly targeted audiences.

Dissemination/Communication KPIs

Tool/channel	Type	Metric value	Coverage
FORGE-AI website	Quantitative Report	>2000 visits per year at the project end >300 downloads	International researchers and general public
Press echoes	Quantitative	10	EU, Georgia, region
On-line newsletters	Quantitative	>6	International
Magazine publications (e.g. in Research and Innovation by Research Media)	Quantitative	>2	International
Participation in conferences, exhibitions and other events	Qualitative in terms of participation increasing	>14, at least 2 exhibitions	EU, Georgia
Publicity about FORGE-AI events (symposium, conference)	Quantitative	3 event promotional campaigns in SM	EU, Georgia, region
FORGE-AI Exhibition at final Conference	Quantitative	1	EU, Georgia, region
FORGE-AI on social media	Content updates	>3 per month	International
Liaisons with other initiatives	Quantitative	>5	EU, Georgia, region

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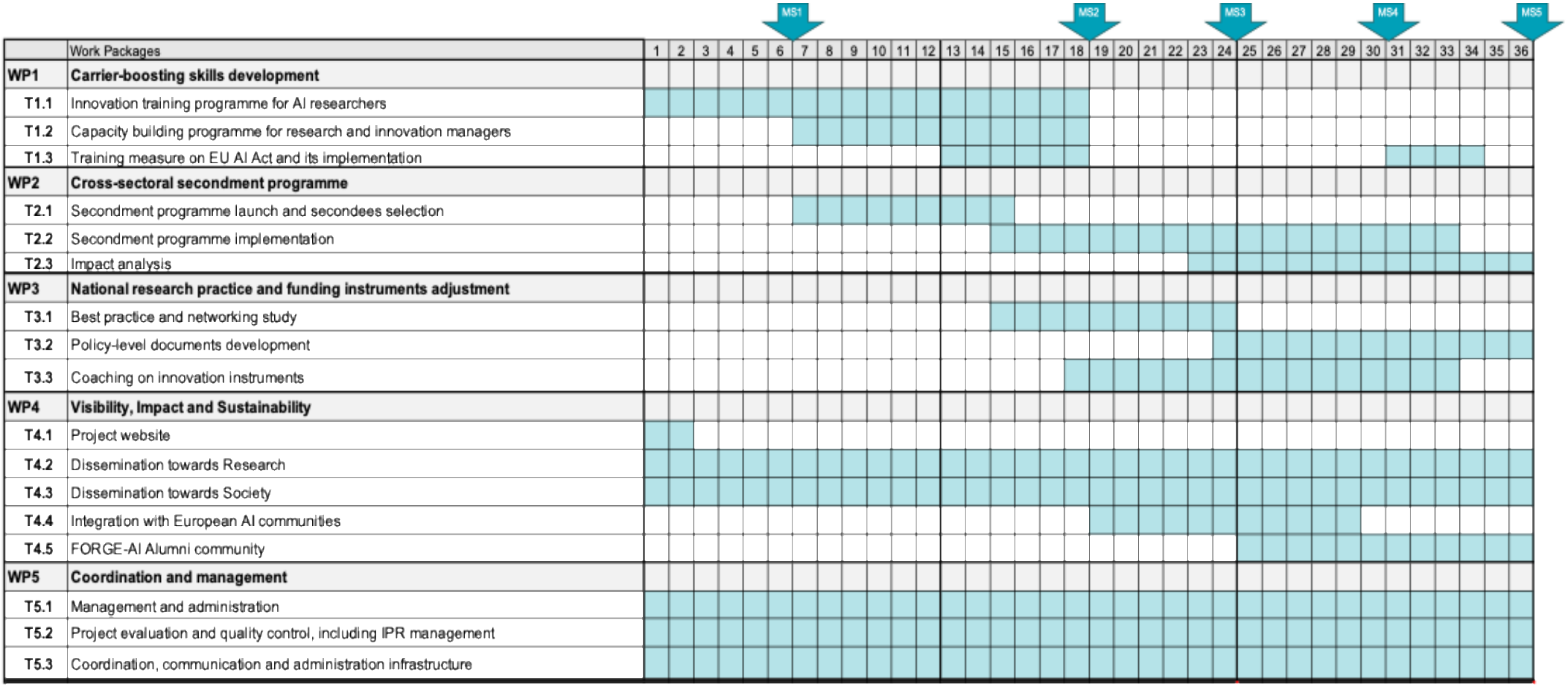
2.3 Summary

KEY ELEMENT OF THE IMPACT SECTION

SPECIFIC NEEDS	EXPECTED RESULTS	D & E & C MEASURES
What are the specific needs that triggered this project? Georgia needs to rapidly improve its competitiveness in the area of AI innovation to attain its development and EU integration goals. For that the country needs to attract and retain young AI R&I talents by offering them attractive multi-optional career opportunities. There is a need to integrate innovation-related capacity building measures into all researcher training activities and boost the cross-sector mobility. All this needs policy and culture shift.	*What do you expect to generate by the end of the project?* • Modular innovation skills training programme for AI researchers, research managers and other R&I talents consisting of at least 15 modules (volume 3-4 ECTS credits) and granting micro-credentials • A cohort of 25 AI R&I talents spent in total 210 months on cross-sector secondments in Europe/region, plus 18 months in Armenia, and improved cross-sector employability • 2 policy-level documents for triggering systemic improvements	*What dissemination, exploitation and communication measures will you apply to the results?* • *Uptake-ready online platform with innovation skills training materials suitable for various scenarios of replication, promoted on the national level and recommended for re-use on the Governmental level (direct dissemination to multipliers)* • *Research symposium "EU-Georgia cooperation in Artificial Intelligence: industrial track" highlighting secondment projects (at least 50 participants from Georgia, Armenia and the EU) in Germany* • *National conference "Georgian Artificial Intelligence Research and Innovation: European path" (at least 100 participants, policy level, industrial panel and exhibition)* • *Web platform (website + social media) of the project and its Alumni.* • *Publications, media reports, presentations, briefings.*

TARGET GROUPS	OUTCOMES	IMPACTS
Who will use or further up-take the results of the project? Who will benefit from the results of the project? • GE/AM: AI researchers and research managers pursuing cross-sector careers • GE: Research training providers (Universities, RTOs, innovative businesses) • GE/AM: Research entrepreneurs (incl. startups) • EU: AI research community thanks to better networking with Georgian/ Armenian AI research and businesses • GE: Society at large thanks to more AI-powered products and services	*What change do you expect to see after successful dissemination and exploitation of project results to the target group(s)?* • Better structured innovation support system in Georgia, with funding instruments supporting innovation skills development and cross-sector mobility. • Innovation training included into regular research training activities (e.g. PhD programmes), contributing to more startups and technology transfer activities. • Regular cross-sector mobility of researchers and, as consequence, interoperability of research careers especially in the area of AI. • Circulation of AI R&I talents between Georgia, region and the EU contributing to AI capacity building.	*What are the expected wider scientific, economic and societal effects of the project contributing to the expected impacts outlined in the respective destination in the work programme?* • Attractiveness of research careers for young talents • Reverted brain drain thanks for better employment of AI R&I talents in Georgia (more options, higher salaries) • Better quality and acceptability of research outcomes in the field of application-oriented AI research thanks to better awareness of the market requirements. • Better quality AI-powered products and services available in Georgia thanks to more AI businesses and lower sectoral barriers for knowledge circulation.

Gantt Chart


MS1
MS2
MS3
MS4
MS5
Work Packages
1 2 3 4 5 6 7 8 9 10 11 12 13 14 15 16 17 18 19 20 21 22 23 24 25 26 27 28 29 30 31 32 33 34 35 36
WP1 Carrier-boosting skills development
T1.1 Innovation training programme for AI researchers
T1.2 Capacity building programme for research and innovation managers
T1.3 Training measure on EU AI Act and its implementation
WP2 Cross-sectoral secondment programme
T2.1 Secondment programme launch and secondees selection
T2.2 Secondment programme implementation
T2.3 Impact analysis
WP3 National research practice and funding instruments adjustment
T3.1 Best practice and networking study
T3.2 Policy-level documents development
T3.3 Coaching on innovation instruments
WP4 Visibility, Impact and Sustainability
T4.1 Project website
T4.2 Dissemination towards Research
T4.3 Dissemination towards Society
T4.4 Integration with European AI communities
T4.5 FORGE-AI Alumni community
WP5 Coordination and management
T5.1 Management and administration
T5.2 Project evaluation and quality control, including IPR management
T5.3 Coordination, communication and administration infrastructure

3. Quality and efficiency of the implementation #@QUA-LIT-QL@# #@WRK-PLA-WP@#

3.1 Work plan and resources

As described in section 1.2, the work plan is composed of 5 work packages: 3 of them represent 3 phases supported by the work packages on Visibility, Impact and Sustainability, as well as Coordination and Management.

- Work package 1 "Career-boosting skills development" will include the tasks related to the training programme design and delivery. These activities will build an initial set of innovation skills to a representative group of AI R&I talents to be further developed in WP2. The training programme developed and piloted in this work package will represent one of the major tangible outcomes of the project.
- Work package 2 "Cross-sector secondment programme" will implement a significant cross-sector cross-border mobility programme for 25 selected R&I talents accounting to 228 person/months on secondments. The tasks will include the secondees selection on the basis of their Secondment and Career Development Plans, the secondments implementation, monitoring and evaluation.
- Work package 3 "National R&I practice and funding instruments adjustment" will build on WP1 and WP2 by collecting the analytical impact assessment information for policy documents development. In addition, WP3 will include the networking activities with several EU networks in the field of AI and innovation aimed at learning the best practice of large-scale innovation capacity building.
- Work package 4 "Visibility, Impact and Sustainability" integrates dissemination, communication and sustainability activities as presented in the section 2.2. The most visible and impactful activities include the project symposium and final Conference, project Alumni and web presence.
- Work package 5 "Coordination and Management". A European project of such scale, incorporating activities which involve big group of people, requires solid and effective leadership and management. The coordinator (GTU) will be supported by the experienced European experts in running daily management activities in accordance with the Grant Agreement, Consortium Agreement and European best practice.

Budget allocation:

	Amount (in EUR)	Percentage (%)
Budget allocated to Widening countries	1,952,125.00	71%
Budget allocated to non-Widening countries	798,750.00	29%
Total EU requested budget	2,750,875.00	100%

3.2 Capacity of participants and consortium as a whole #@CON-SOR-CS@# #@PRJ-MGT-PM@#

Partner	Related expertise	Role in the project
	Academia	
GTU	The largest agenda-setting technical University of Georgia: carries out AI-related research and PhD programmes, incorporates major AI-related research institutes, such as MICM (coordinator), Institute of Cybernetics, etc. Coordinator of the GAIN project (HEP Twinning)	Coordinator. Contribution to training needs identification and hosting training events. Selection of secondees (7), appointing the secondee ombudsperson, contribution to the impact analysis. Hosting the final Conference.
TSU	The largest national classic University with the spectrum of core AI and AI-adjacent disciplines, including PhD programmes. Expertise in SSH, including Ethics of AI	Contribution to training needs identification and hosting training events. Selection of secondees (7), contribution to the impact analysis, dissemination towards academia.

DFKI	One of the largest non-profit AI research organizations in the world (1,600 staff members) established as a private-public partnership in 1988. Focus on application-oriented research in the field of AI-based software technologies. More than 120 startups spined off from DFKI in the last 30 years.	Contribution to the training programme's design and delivery, EU AI Act training leader. Leader of WP2, hosting 8 secondees. Organizer of the EU best practice and networking study visits (WP3). Contributor to dissemination in the EU.
Triathlon	Entrepreneurship and innovation support ecosystem of Saarland University. Since the beginning of the 90ths designs and runs University-based innovation training programmes for students and staff members, startup coaching and incentives programmes, other related activities in the University.	EU training leader in WP1, design and delivery of several training modules. Deep Dive coaching. Hosting 3 secondees according to the plan (topic: innovation support services in academic environment). Dissemination in the EU.
Business		
DAL	DAL is an AI company bringing to the market the family of Natural Language Processing products (Enagramm: spell-checker, transcriber, TTS, OCR, etc.) for information processing in several languages, including Georgian. Market leader in this field.	DAL will contribute with the business perspective to the training needs definition and training design. It will select 1 managerial and 2 research talents for the secondment programme to boost their careers.
HelioAI	Founded in 2023, HelioAI is a company bringing to the market an AI-powered recruitment management system operating in Georgian language and running personality tests. The first such product in Georgia.	The company will also contribute to and benefit from capacity building activities. HelioAI will select 1 research and 1 managerial secondees for the programme.
AILab	The company develops the first Georgian Large Language Model, an only Generative AI model available for this unique low-resourced language. Using this advance, the company works to improve the machine translation tools in Georgia.	The company will select 1 research talent for a 12-month secondment at DFKI (e.g. LLM training) and 1 managerial talent for a shorter secondment at Triathlon.
YNN	Research-intensive private entity with competences in AI for biotechnologies and NLP. Research for private funders and public beneficiaries.	Hosting 2 research secondees from GTU and TSU. Participation in training. Dissemination in Armenia.
CC	Key player in startup incubation and acceleration since 2011. Runs several Innovation centres, including in AI&Robotics. Total number of startups hosted more than 300. Designs and delivers a full spectrum of support services (co-working, events and meetings organization, etc.). Pledger of EIT Deep Tech Talents Initiative.	Co-definition of training needs and programme design. Contribution to training for innovation managers. Hosting 3 secondees (topic: management of innovation) and placing 4 academic secondees to business residents of its innovation centres. Dissemination in the EU.
Triathlon*	In addition to providing innovation support services to students and staff, Triathlon runs 3 University business incubators and is a direct link to the regional Science Park Saar, hosting and coaching in total up to 100 startups	Placing 5 academic secondees to business residents of its business incubators. Coaching services.
Policy and community level		
SRNSF	National science funding agency. Designs and implements several grant programmes, including	Co-definition of training needs. Training promotion and support. Sending 2

	academic mobility programme. Coordinates EU-Georgia RTD cooperation across sectors.	secondees (topic: management of innovation). Leader of WP3, key contribution to policy documents development. Dissemination in Georgia.
GITA	National innovation and technology agency. Runs startup grant programmes (ca. 400 startups supported since 2014), runs a network of Technoparks and innovation centres across the country.	Co-definition of training needs. Training promotion and support. Sending 2 secondees (topic: management of innovation). Leader of impact assessment. Contribution to policy documents development. Dissemination in Georgia.
GAIA	National AI association with corporate and individual membership. With the mission to promote the adoption of AI in Georgia, GAIA has organized several international events, supports young talents in career development, expert body to Government.	Dissemination leader (WP4 leader). Promotion of the training programme in Georgia. Developer and host of the project web resources. Key organizer of the final Conference.
ICARTI	Georgian Horizon Europe CL 4 (Digital, Industry and Space) National Contact Point. Georgian training provider on research and innovation funding instruments, leader of Georgian technology clusters dialogue.	Leader of WP1, leader in co-definition of training needs, contribution to the training programme design and delivery, promotion and participants selection. Training uptaker and multiplier. Dissemination in Georgia
DFKI	Due to its role of the large research performer, DFKI is involved in major European AI policy and community initiatives. Co-founder of CLAIRE. Founding member of EIT KICs. Contributor to establishing ADRA (adra-e WP leader), etc.	DFKI will organize a series of meetings between the Georgian team and ADRA Association, CLAIRE leadership, Accelerate programme management of EIT Manufacturing.

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Tables for section 3.1

Table 3.1g: 'Subcontracting costs' items

No subcontracting planned.

Table 3.1h: 'Purchase costs' items (travel and subsistence, equipment and other goods, works and services)

Participant Number/Short Name 1/GTU		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	118,850	Costs for: • 6 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (6 X 750 euro = = 4500 euro), subsistence for 60 secondment/months (60 X 1475 euro = 88500 euro); • 1 secondment to Armenian partner, travel tickets (1 X 100 euro = 100 euro), subsistence for 12 secondment/months (12 X 750 euro = 9000 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 8 trips (8 X 1675 euro = 13400 euro); • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1675 = 3350 euro).
Equipment	0	

Other goods, works and services	11,350	• Organization costs for: ✓ Final Conference, 3350 euro ✓ Training workshops, 1000 euro (including printing/publishing, transport). • Certificate on the financial statements (CFS) - 7000 euro.
Total	130,200	

Participant Number/Short Name 2/SRNSF		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	30,400	Costs for: • 2 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (2 X 750 euro = 1500 euro), subsistence for 12 secondment/months (12 X 1475 euro = 17700 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 5 trips (5 X 1600 euro = 8000 euro). • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1600 euro = 3200 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	30,400	

Participant Number/Short Name 3/GITA		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	32,400	Costs for: • 2 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (2 X 750 euro = 1500 euro), subsistence for 12 secondment/months (12 X 1475 euro = 17700 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 6 trips (6 X 1650 euro = 9900 euro). • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1650 euro = 3300 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	32,400	

Participant Number/Short Name 4/TSU		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	120,200	Costs for: • 6 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (6 X 790 euro = = 4740 euro), subsistence for 60 secondment/months (60 X 1560 euro = 93600 euro); • 1 secondment to Armenian partner, travel tickets (1 X 160 euro = 160 euro), subsistence for 6 secondment/months (6 X 800 euro = 4800 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 8 trips (8 X 1690 euro = 13520 euro); • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1690 euro = 3380 euro).

Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	120,200	

Participant Number/Short Name 5/GAIA		
	Cost (€)	Justification
Travel and subsistence	13,000	Costs for attending: • conferences in Europe, up to 6 trips (6 X 1625 euro = 9750 euro); • 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1625 euro = 3250 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	10,000	• Organization costs for the Final Conference, 4000 euro; • Promotional materials, 2000 euro; • ADR Forum Exhibition participation fee, (2 years X 2000 euro = 4000 euro).
Total	23,000	

Participant Number/Short Name 6/DAL		
	Cost (€)	Justification
Travel and subsistence	62,600	Costs for: • 3 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (3 X 750 euro = 2250 euro), subsistence for 30 secondment/months (30 X 1475 euro = 44250 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 8 trips (8 X 1610 euro = 12880 euro); • 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1610 euro = 3220 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	62,600	

Participant Number/Short Name 7/HelioAI		
	Cost (€)	Justification
Travel and subsistence	43,400	Costs for: • 2 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (2 X 750 euro = 1500 euro), subsistence for 18 secondment/months (18 X 1475 euro = 26550 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 8 trips (8 X 1535 euro = 12280 euro); • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1535 euro = 3070 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	43,400	

Participant Number/Short Name 8/AILab		
	Cost (€)	Justification

Travel and subsistence	43,400	Costs for: • 2 secondments to European partners, travel tickets (2 X 750 euro = 1500 euro), subsistence for 18 secondment/months (18 X 1475 euro = 26550 euro); • Attending conferences in Europe, up to 8 trips (8 X 1535 euro = 12280 euro); • Attending 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1535 euro = 3070 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	43,400	

Participant Number/Short Name 9/ICARTI		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	10,000	Costs for attending: • conferences in Europe, up to 6 trips (6 X 1250 euro = 7500 euro); • 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1250 euro = 2500 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	10,000	

Participant Number/Short Name 13/YNN		
	Cost (€)	**Justification**
Travel and subsistence	14,000	Costs for attending: • conferences in Europe, up to 6 trips (6 X 1750 euro = 10500 euro); • 2 Project meetings in Europe, 2 persons (2 X 1750 euro = 3500 euro).
Equipment	0	
Other goods, works and services	0	
Total	14,000	

Remarks:

- All the costs in the justification columns of Tables 3.1h are estimated costs:
  - ✓ The travel costs to Europe range between 750 – 790 euro
  - ✓ The travel costs to Armenia range between 100 – 160 euro
  - ✓ Subsistence costs for secondments to European partners range between 1475 – 1560 euro
  - ✓ Subsistence costs for secondments to Armenian partner range between 750 – 800 euro
  - ✓ The travel and subsistence costs to attend the conferences and project meetings in Europe range between 1250 – 1690 euro.

  The beneficiaries will use the actual costs in line with the usual accounting practice in the countries.
- Final Conference will be organized at the end of the project after month 30, when all the secondees are back.
- Training workshops will be organized between month 6 and month 18.
- 1st project meeting is a Kickoff in Tbilisi, Georgia; 2 project meetings will be held at 2nd and 3rd years in Germany and France.
- The relevant high-level (e.g. IEEE, HCI International, ExLing etc.) conferences will be identified

during the project.

Other costs categories' items (e.g. internally invoiced goods and services)

No such costs planned.

In-kind contributions' provided by third parties

No In-kind contributions planned.

Affiliated entities

No affiliated entities are foreseen in the project.

Associated partners

No associated partners are foreseen in the project.

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4. Ethics self-assessment

4.1. Ethical dimension of the objectives, methodology and likely impact

The project does not carry out any activities raising ethical concern. At the same time, the individual secondment project might potentially include research activities with ethical implications (e.g. collection and processing of personal data). All such cases will be identified at the stage of selection and the secondees planning such research, as well as their hosting teams, will be requested to provide the EU regulation compliant plan of handling ethical issues. A European hosting organization will be responsible for ensuring the compliance during the project implementation in line with regular practices.

4.2. Compliance with ethical principles and relevant legislations

The project will adhere to European Codes of Conduct for Research Integrity, Recruitment of Researchers and European Charter for Researchers. In particular, the ethical and moral principles outlined in these Codes of Conducts will be allied in the process of selection and monitoring of secondees, evaluation of their achievements and supporting their professional careers.